

sustained support, mentorship, and opportunities for women already within the STEM ecosystem to grow and lead.

How are you ensuring long-term sustainability and meaningful impact for the Manthan initiative?

Let me illustrate this with the RSVC initiative about which I talked earlier.

Launched about a year ago, RSVC focuses on bringing affordable and sustainable technologies to rural areas. It builds on the earlier RuTAG (Rural Technology Action Group) programme, under which seven IITs were tasked with developing technologies for rural needs. So far, 64 technologies have been developed, addressing challenges related to livelihoods, water management, and agriculture.

The next step involved scaling these solutions, which is where RSVCs come in. Each centre, managed by local communities and funded privately, typically serves around 50 villages.

Designed to be self-sustaining, RSVCs generate income through services such as rapid soil testing, which now delivers results within hours rather than days. The objective is for each RSVC to become self-sufficient within a few years. With NABARD as a key partner, 50 centres have already been established in the first year without government funding.

The next phase aims to expand this network further through partnerships and collaboration. This model ensures both sustainability and large-scale impact by combining local empowerment, private participation, and scalable frameworks capable of reaching every part of the country.

Where can one find information or listings of the existing RSVCs?

Details of established RSVCs are available on the Manthan platform under the RSVC-AMRIT section.

This section provides information on each RSVC, along with photographs of the respective centres.

If an organisation is interested in establishing an RSVC, what process should be followed and whom should they contact?

Any NGO, foundation, academic institution, or CSR entity interested in establishing an RSVC may submit an expression of interest along with a concept note via email to industry-engagement@psa.gov.in and register on the Manthan platform to initiate the RSVC set-up process.

Could you elaborate on NABARD's role in this initiative and the institutional support it provides to RSVCs?

NABARD plays a strategic enabling role in the RSVC initiative through the following key verticals:

1. Technology sandboxing: Identification, validation, deployment, and acceleration of technologies for RSVCs based on identified problem statements.

2. Monitoring and evaluation: Through the RSVC-AMRIT platform, NABARD monitors RSVC establishment, technologies deployed, and impact generated in terms of skilling, livelihoods created, productivity gains, income enhancement, and entrepreneurship development.

3. Market linkages: Facilitated through ONDC, the National Rural Livelihood Mission (NRLM), the Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD), and other agencies.

4. Identification and engagement with implementation partners: Assessing experience, institutional strengths, community engagement, and technology proficiency.

5. Capacity building: Development of training modules for RSVCs, Self-Help Groups (SHGs), and Farmer Producer Organisations (FPOs).

What is the long-term vision for RSVCs, and how many centres are

planned over the next five years?

By 2026 end, RSVCs are expected to scale to over 150 centres. Over the next five years, we envision establishing more than 500 RSVCs across the country, creating a nationwide network for rural technology deployment, employment generation, and entrepreneurship development.

For young innovators and entrepreneurs following this conversation, what message would you like to share?

This is a defining moment for India. There has never been a better time or place for innovation and entrepreneurship. Be bold. If you have ideas, passion, energy, stamina, and perseverance to take on challenges, step forward and pursue them.

The government has created strong frameworks, resources, and policies to support innovators, with further initiatives underway.

Under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi, technology is central to India's growth narrative and to the vision of *Viksit Bharat*. In successive Independence Day addresses, the Prime Minister has emphasised the importance of innovation. The call of *Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan, Jai Vigyan, and Jai Anusandhan* reflects the nation's enduring commitment to research and discovery.

Through this platform, it is also important to highlight an upcoming step—the implementation of the ₹1 trillion corpus for research and development. This fund is focused on supporting private sector-driven R&D and complements the Anusandhan National Research Foundation, which supports academia-led research.

Together, these two major initiatives, one industry-driven and the other academia-driven, will help create a robust and balanced innovation ecosystem. For young people, there could not be a better time to dream, create, and lead the future. **EFY**